Revision Date:
12/01/2025

Background:
All CalFresh household (HH) members must be screened for work registration. The general CalFresh work requirements are referred to as work registration and non-exempt HH members are referred to as work registrants. Work registration differs from CalFresh Employment & Training (E&T) and the Able-Bodied Adult Without Dependents (ABAWD) time limit. For guidance on E&T or the ABAWD time limit reference CalFresh Program Guide (CFPG) Sections 63-903 and 63-904, respectively.

Purpose:
This section provides guidance on the rules for work registration screening, exemptions, requirements, and changes in exemption status. The policy was updated to add the requirement to provide an oral and written explanation of the general CalFresh work rules to all CalFresh HHs.

Policy:
Screen all CalFresh HH members for work registration at initial application, recertification, and when there is a change in work registration exemption status. It is not mandatory for work registrants to participate in E&T as a condition of CalFresh eligibility.

1. Screening Process

Provide the CalFresh Notice of Work Rules (CF 886) and an oral explanation to all CalFresh HHs, this includes work registrants and those who are exempt. All CalFresh HH members are subject to work registration unless they meet an exemption. Register all non-exempt CalFresh HH members for work registration.

Screening includes:
- Registering non-exempt HH members between the ages of 16 through 59.
- Providing the CF 886 and an oral explanation of the CalFresh work rules.
- Informing HHs of available employment services.
- Referring appropriate HH members who would like to voluntarily participate in CalFresh E&T.

Document the screening information in the case record, including HH members who are work registrants and who are exempt.

2. Work Registration Exemptions

HH members exempt from work registration at initial application or recertification remain exempt until their next recertification unless they experience a change that impacts their status. HH members are exempt from work registration if they meet at least one of the criteria below:
- Under 16 or over 59 years of age.
- A 16 or 17-year-old who is not head of household can meet work registration requirements by attending school or an employment training program at least half-time.
- Physically or mentally unfit for employment.
- Subject to and complying with any work requirements under Title IV of the Social Security Act including the CalWORKs program.

- A parent of or responsible for the care of a dependent child under age 6.
  - The child does not have to be a member of the CalFresh HH or living in the home.
- Responsible for the care of an incapacitated person.
  - The incapacitated person does not have to be a member of the CalFresh HH or living in the home.
- Applying for, or receiving, unemployment insurance benefits.
- A regular participant in a drug or alcohol treatment program.
- Employed or self-employed at least 30 hours per week or receiving weekly earnings at least equal to the federal minimum wage multiplied by 30 hours.
  - The calculation of federal minimum wage x 30 hours = $217.50 weekly – This amount is based on 2025 federal minimum wage and subject to change based on federal updates.
- Enrolled in a school, training program, or institution of higher education on at least a half-time basis.
  - Students enrolled at least half-time in an institution of higher education must meet student eligibility requirements.

3. Work Registration Requirements

HH members are considered registered when their status is confirmed in the automated system. Complete the following steps to confirm registration:

- Complete applicable data collection screens in the automated system.
  - Confirm work registration status in the CalFresh Eligibility Benefit Determination Calculation (EDBC) Summary screen.
- Document the information in the case record.

All work registrants must comply with the following general CalFresh work requirements:

- Accept an offer for suitable employment. Employment is considered suitable unless:
  - The wage offered is less than federal minimum wage, the state minimum wage, or 80% of the federal minimum wage if neither the federal nor state minimum wage is applicable.
  - The employment offered is on a piece-rate basis and the average hourly wage the employee can reasonably be expected to earn is less than the applicable hourly wages specified above.
  - The HH member, as a condition of employment or continuing employment, is required to join, resign from, or refrain from joining any legitimate labor organization.
  - The work offered is at a site subject to a strike or lockout at the time of the offer.
  - The degree of risk to health and safety is unreasonable.
  - The employment offered within the first 30 days of registration is not in the member's major field of experience.
  - The distance from the member's home to the place of employment is unreasonable considering the expected wage and the time and cost of commuting.
  - The daily commute time exceeds 2 hours per day, not including the transport of a child to and from a childcare facility.
  - The distance to the place of employment prohibits walking and neither public nor private transportation is available to transport the HH member to the job site.
  - The working hours or nature of the employment interferes with the HH member's religious observances, convictions, or beliefs.
- Register for work or be registered at the time of application and every 12 months thereafter.
- Provide sufficient information to determine employment status or availability for work.

- Not voluntarily quit a job of 30 or more hours a week or reduce work hours to fewer than 30 hours a week without good cause.
  - The calculation of federal minimum wage x 30 hours = $217.50 weekly – This amount is based on 2025 federal minimum wage and subject to future federal updates.

Refer to Section 63-159 for guidance on voluntary job quit or reduction of work hours.

5. Changes in Work Registration Exemption Status

When a change in circumstance impacts a HH member's work registration status during the certification period, screen them for another work registration exemption. If the HH member is not exempt, then register them as a work registrant at:

- The Eligibility Status Report (SAR 7).
- A change that is a mandatory mid-period report, refer to Section 63-283.
- A voluntary mid-period report that is Verified Upon Receipt (VUR), refer to Section 63-283.

If any of these changes occur and the HH member is subject to work registration, then they must be screened for another exemption and registered within 10 days of the date the change was reported.

The following are examples of registering a HH member at the time a change is reported:

Example: Mandatory Mid-Period Report	
Scenario	HH consists of 40-year-old dad and his 10-year-old daughter. At intake, it was verified that dad was earning a gross amount of $250.00 per week, therefore he was exempt from work registration. At SAR 7, dad's gross earnings dropped below $217.50 per week (amount based on 2025 federal minimum wage and subject to future federal updates).
Outcome	Dad no longer meets a work registration exemption because he is earning less than 30 hours per week at federal minimum wage ($217.50 per week). Dad is now subject to work registration and must be registered within 10 days.
Example: Mid-Period Change Report That is VUR	
Scenario	At recertification HH consisted of 30-year-old mom and her 4-year-old son. Mom reported to be earning a gross amount of $195.00 per week. Mom was exempt from work registration due to caring for a child under 6 years of age. Mid-period she voluntarily reported her son is no longer in the home; he is living with his father.
Outcome	Mom no longer meets a work registration exemption because she is no longer caring for a child under 6 and does not meet any other exemptions. Mom is now subject to work registration and must be registered within 10 days.

References:

All County Letter (ACL) 19-93, 20-10, 22-74, 22-99, 23-30, 24-42, and 25-64.

Sunset Date:

This policy will be reviewed for continuance on or by 11/30/2028.

Approval for Release:



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